

of this in your head, you can make things fun with some real life role-play!

Surely, someone in your team will have dreamed of the silver screen at some point in their life. Ask them to get into the character of the persona (once they're familiar with it, of course) and throw some questions at them. Or ask them to perform some tasks as the persona. You're only limited by your imagination here!

Creating Mental models

A “Mental Model” is a tool for understanding the underlying reasons why a user does something, like go to a club or buy a pet. It examines the root motivations of why a user would want to accomplish a certain task, by visualising their thought processes in detail. They can be used within the context of personas using your product, or even in the context of the daily life of a persona, in order to identify design opportunities, or problems that need solving.

Experience Maps

Experience maps are a type of deliverable that documents a use-case scenario involving a persona. This map records the persona accomplishing a goal using the product or service, in the way a process diagram would, but in more detail. For example, a persona using an e-commerce application to buy something. It includes all the “touchpoints”, that is, the moments the persona interacts with the product or service, as well as their feelings at the time – how they're feeling, what they're thinking and what they're doing. This can give insight into possible causes of frustration as well as ideas for improving the experience.

Usage lifecycles

Lifecycles showcase the various stages of use/interaction with a product or service. They're important because after having used the product over time, users' goals and behaviours will change over time. The usage lifecycle can be broadly categorised into five stages:

1. First Contact: This is when people become aware of or learn about your service or product for the first time. They form their first perceptions, but not first impressions as they haven't yet decided whether they like it or not. At this stage, the users only have to decide whether they want to try the product/service or not.